position, we strengthen our position. Therefore, comrades, this help, I would say, is not only for comrade Walter and the Germans in the GDR but for others as well.

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Upon reflection, Khrushchev later commented that the drain of workers was creating a ‘simply disastrous situation’ in the GDR, which was already suffering from a shortage of manual and specialised labour. ‘If things had continued like this much longer, I don’t know what would have happened.’ Looking tired and drawn, Ulbricht informed the Politburo on 7 August that Moscow had given permission to control the border, as Honecker recounted: ‘On 11 August 1961, the Volkskammer declared that a grave danger to the peace in Europe existed. It charged the GDR’s Council of Ministers with preparing and implementing all measures which were necessary to safeguard peace.’

One of the grim ironies of the story was that many Volkskammer MPs had no inkling of what was to come. The following day, the Council of Ministers passed a resolution, as Honecker recounted, that the ‘border between socialist and capitalist Europe be placed under proper control’. At this crucial moment, Erich Mielke was busily informing senior Stasi officials that measures would be taken against flight from the GDR, with the ring around Berlin of particular focus. While his language was vague, its implications were not. ‘All preparatory work is to be carried out under the strictest secrecy,’ he said, adding: ‘The entire operation has the code name “Rose”.’8 Later that afternoon, Honecker found himself at the police operations centre on Keibelstraße. To those who saw him at close quarters, he appeared in high spirits. ‘From there,’ Honecker noted, ‘I was in constant contact with the commanding officers and staff of the armed forces, the district committees of the SED in Berlin, Frankfurt/Oder and Potsdam, the central government departments, the Berlin Municipal Council and the regional councils of Frankfurt/Oder and Potsdam.’9